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Digital Leisure

Technology Beyond Work

**Meera Vankipuram and
Aparna Krishnakumar**

Forty-year-old Jomiben Jairanbhai of Madhura village in Satalpur, Gujarat, has studied up to Standard VII, but is adept at using e-mail—"I learnt how to e-mail during a workshop conducted by SEWA. I was a little doubtful, but equally determined to learn about the computer and make my world a little easier." Jomiben, who is proficient at Bharathaam, a tradi-

tional form of tapestry, vividly recalls, "When the designs were made on paper, we had to maintain records with great care. Now, with the PC, we create all our designs on the computer." Gauriben B of Satalpur is also a Bharathaam artisan, she says, "our art is recognised not just in India, but we also get orders from abroad, thanks to our Web site. Our designs are stored on a computer and we can customise them depending on our customer's needs."

Mobile phones have allowed these artisans to stay in touch with

their peers from other villages about new designs and on the status of orders.

In a country where women's empowerment is a work-in-progress; a voluntary organisation has deployed technology to help women help themselves.

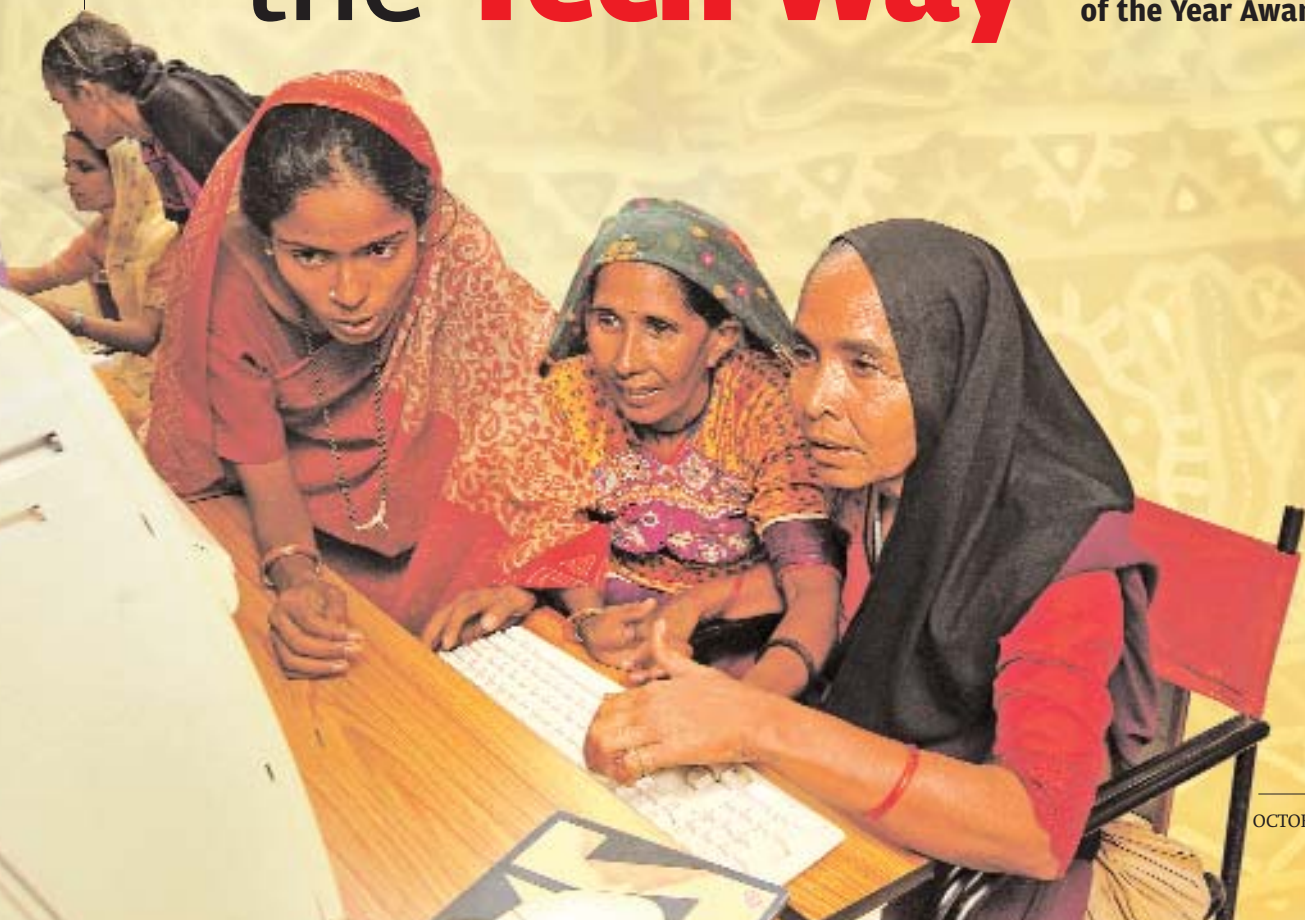
Founded by social worker Elaben Bhatt, the Self Employed Women's Association (SEWA), based in Ahmedabad, is one of the most powerful and well-known NGOs in India. SEWA strives to achieve self-reliance for women.

Registered as a trade-union in

Touched by Tech

Women on Top, the Tech Way

Here's SEWA, an all-women NGO that believes in self-reliance through technology. No wonder it bagged NASSCOM's Best IT User of the Year Award



Photographs: Jiten Gandhi Imaging; Jayan Narayanan